

Kansas - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-line Power Four team with enough run-game/defensive continuity to be competitive.
Preseason consensus	Unranked (zero votes) · No. 58 (+3.3)
Returning production	58% (No. 41) overall · Off. 49% (No. 82) · Def. 67% (No. 11)
Primer power rating	+3.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.9 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ - Roughly similar overall: the skill-position reload and defensive returning-production signal create upside.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Kansas projects as a multiple-formation offense built around a two-back RB Edwards/RB Willis core while QB Ballard and QB Marshall compete to replace QB Jalon Daniels, paired with a 4-2-5 defense anchored by LB Trey Lathan.

Bottom line: Kansas has a credible six-win path because the run game, LB core and special teams are useful foundations, but unresolved QB/OL roles and poor 2025 explosive-play defense keep the floor volatile.

Beats expectations if: QB Cole Ballard or QB Isaiah Marshall quickly becomes a competent distributor, RB Dylan Edwards/RB Yasin Willis preserve the explosive-run identity, the OL stabilizes, and the defense improves explosive-play prevention.

Disappoints if: The QB competition remains unsettled into games, OL turnover creates obvious-passing-down problems, McAlpine's absence exposes defensive-tackle depth, and the secondary repeats the 2025 explosive-play leakage.

Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB question:** Starting quarterback remains unresolved between QB Cole Ballard and QB Isaiah Marshall; Chase Jenkins is currently third.
- 2 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense had real underlying quality-EPA/play No. 33, success rate No. 24 and explosive-play rate No. 12-even though Kansas finished only 5-7.
- 3 **Returning production:** Returning production is defense-heavy: 49% offense (No. 82) versus 67% defense (No. 11), making the offensive rebuild the larger continuity problem.
- 4 **? Defensive availability:** DT Tre'veon McAlpine and Justin Thurman are out for the season, with McAlpine's ACL injury directly reshaping the defensive-tackle rotation.
- 5 **? Play-caller:** Andy Kotelnicki is the 2026 offensive play-caller/final-say authority, so the unresolved offensive question is personnel execution, not who calls the plays.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (3-6 Big 12)	● Poor
Scoring	28.1 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	390.5 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	168.2 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.73 YPA · 23 TD / 8 INT	● Good / above average
Third downs	38.5%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	26.8 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	387.2 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	173.1 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Below average
Pass defense	214.1 YPG · 7.24 YPA · 19 TD allowed	● Below average

Kansas was a middling conventional offense (28.1 pts/g No. 63; total offense No. 68) and a weaker defense (26.8 allowed No. 80; total defense No. 86; rush defense No. 97; pass-efficiency defense No. 102). The record and traditional profile therefore reflected a team without a consistently winning side of the ball.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+3.21 · No. 40	● Good / above average
Off. EPA/play	+0.093 · No. 33	● Very good
Off. success rate	47.5% · No. 24	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	15.4% · No. 12	● Elite
Havoc allowed	13.4% · No. 37	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.99 · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.054 · No. 90	● Below average
Def. success rate allowed	41.5% · No. 69	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	13.7% · No. 116	● Poor
Havoc created	17.3% · No. 32	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: The 5-7 record understates a top-33 offense by EPA, success rate and explosiveness. The defense could create havoc but was poor in EPA allowed and explosive prevention.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Lance Leipold - returning	● ↔ Lance Leipold's return keeps the program identity and staff structure stable.
Offensive play-caller	Andy Kotelnicki - associate head coach; 2026 play-caller/final-say authority	● ↔ Andy Kotelnicki holds 2026 play-calling/final-say authority, giving the offense a clearly defined game-day lead.
Co-OC	Matt Lubick - returning co-offensive coordinator/tight ends	● ↔ Matt Lubick returns as co-OC/TE, adding continuity beneath the established play-calling structure.
DC	D.K. McDonald - returning	● ↔ D.K. McDonald returns, preserving defensive-system continuity.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Dylan Edwards	Kansas State	● ↑ Top-two back and return-game weapon with Doak Walker recognition.
◆ RB Yasin Willis	Syracuse	● ↔ Major two-back role candidate with Doak Walker recognition; adds size/volume alongside RB Edwards.
◆ WR Nik McMillan	Buffalo	● ↔ Biletnikoff-watchlist newcomer in the major WR rotation, helping replace WR Emmanuel Henderson Jr.
◆ OL Kasen Carpenter	Oklahoma State	● ↔ Center/interior best-five candidate; useful experience but the line remains unsettled.

Out	To	Loss
QB Jalon Daniels	NFL (Tampa Bay), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Kansas loses its 2025 starting quarterback.
OT Enrique Cruz Jr.	NFL (San Francisco), Round 5, No. 179	● ↓ Material starting tackle departs as a 49ers fifth-round pick.
WR Emmanuel Henderson Jr.	NFL (Seattle), Round 6, No. 199	● ↓ Major 2025 receiving/return contributor departs for Seattle, increasing dependence on the transfer WR group.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Worse continuity at QB and OL, even with a talented RB/WR reload.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Bam Crouch	Boston College	● ↔ Current leader at weak-side linebacker and a key piece next to LB Trey Lathan.
◆ DT Eamon Smalls	UAB	● ↔ Moved into the top defensive-tackle rotation after McAlpine's injury.
◆ DT Tre'von McAlpine	Tulane	● ↔ Was a material incoming front piece.

Out	To	Loss
DB Lyrik Rawls	Arizona State	● ↓ Twelve-game starter and Kansas's No. 2 tackler transfers to Arizona State, leaving a major secondary hole.
LB Bangally Kamara	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Nine-start, 56-tackle linebacker departs after signing with Minnesota.

Defensive net: ● ↔ Continuity is better than the offense's and LB Trey Lathan gives Kansas a real anchor.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Multiple pistol/under-center/shotgun structure with a two-back RB Edwards/RB Willis core and an unresolved quarterback competition.	The 2025 offense created explosives at an elite rate.	Replacing QB Jalon Daniels and veteran OL pieces while the exact best five remains unsettled.
Defense	4-2-5 base with LB Trey Lathan established at MLB.	Havoc creation was No. 32 in 2025 and the defense carries a strong 67% returning-production signal.	Explosive-play prevention was No. 116.
Special teams	Model-backed strength with a new kicker.	SP+ special teams No. 9 plus Edwards's planned return usage.	Kicker is a transfer replacement after Laith Marjan's departure.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● C+	● ↓	Low	QB Cole Ballard/QB Isaiah Marshall remain in an unresolved competition.
RB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Dylan Edwards/RB Yasin Willis form a high-upside two-back core.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Nik McMillan leads a transfer-heavy group replacing major production.
TE	● B-	● ↔	Medium	TE Carter Moses provides a recognized major-role option.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	Veteran losses and an unsettled best five create major continuity risk.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	DT Tre'von McAlpine's injury deepens an already changing front.
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Trey Lathan anchors the defense with LB Bam Crouch added.
Secondary	● C+	● ↔	Low	Major turnover meets a 2025 defense ranked No. 116 in explosive prevention.
Special teams	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	SP+ No. 9 and RB/KR Dylan Edwards give the unit real upside.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	High	HC Lance Leipold's staff is stable and Andy Kotelnicki has final play-calling authority.
Overall	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Bowl-line roster with strong RB/defensive continuity but major QB/OL uncertainty.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Dylan Edwards (TR: Kansas State)	RB/KR /PR	● High-upside all-purpose starter	Doak Walker Award	Top-two back and return weapon central to preserving explosive-play offense.
Trey Lathan	LB	● Defensive anchor / high-end conference starter	Bednarik Award · Butkus Award	Established MLB, same-school return and the most decorated current Kansas defender.
◆ Yasin Willis (TR: Syracuse)	RB	● Major-role power back	Doak Walker Award	Shares the top backfield tier with Edwards.
Cole Ballard	QB	● Unproven starter candidate	-	Co-leader of the unresolved QB competition.
Isaiah Marshall	QB	● Unproven starter candidate	-	Co-leader with Ballard and the other plausible answer to replacing Jalon Daniels.
◆ Nik McMillan (TR: Buffalo)	WR	● Upside transfer / major-rotation target	Biletnikoff Award	Biletnikoff-watchlist newcomer who needs to help replace a major receiving departure class.
Carter Moses	TE	● Major-role tight end candidate	John Mackey Award	Mackey-watchlist signal and current major-role projection make him a potentially important stabilizer.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Eamon Smalls (TR: UAB)	DT	● Projected top-rotation transfer	-	McAlpine's ACL injury elevates Smalls into the clearest top-three DT rotation.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	A true bowl-line schedule with two soft nonconference home games and several difficult Big 12 road trips.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 55
Hardest stretch	at Utah -> at Kansas State -> Baylor -> at TCU
Swing games	Arizona State (London), Baylor, UCF, at West Virginia, at Oklahoma State
Advantage	LIU and Middle Tennessee are home games, and the Sept.26 bye follows the London game vs. Arizona State before Kansas resumes with Middle Tennessee.
Expected	5.9 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Bowl-line team with early volatility likely to center on the unresolved QB and rebuilt OL.
Back them when	The matchup allows Kansas to lean on RB Edwards/RB Willis.
Fade/pass when	The opponent can force dropback passing or attack the secondary vertically.
Key monitor	QB Ballard vs. QB Marshall starter decision, Final offensive-line five/alignment, Post-DT McAlpine defensive-tackle rotation, Alexander/Pearson and Davis/Harris secondary roles
Week 1 baseline	vs. LIU: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Kansas -38.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Kansas has more upside than a 5-7 record suggests because last year's offense was efficient and explosive, and RB Dylan Edwards/RB Yasin Willis give the new QB a strong run-game foundation. The problem is that QB and OL - the highest-leverage continuity points - remain unsettled.

LB Trey Lathan anchors a higher-returning defense that still must fix explosive-play prevention after DT Tre'von McAlpine's injury. With SOS No. 55, **5.9 wins and 6-6** is the right bowl-line baseline.

About this primer

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Sources: [2025 stats](#) · [injury update](#) · [QB update](#) · [QB update](#) · [QB update](#) · [OL update](#) · [2026 roster](#) · [Kansas return-game plans for Dylan Edwards](#) · [Kansas defensive tackle rotation](#) · [Kansas weak-side linebacker competition](#)

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